



Liberhan Commission

Set up in 1992 to probe the demolition of the Babri Masjid, it is now on its 47th extension, with each one promised as the last one.



Banerjee and Nanavati commissions

Two commissions, one instituted by the Railways and the other by the Modi Government, were set up to probe the Godhra train fire. Their findings differed.

Commissions of OMISSION

The demand for a judicial inquiry into the Batla House encounter may be politically motivated but it also shows the need for reform or a new method to get at the truth. Not a single probe in the past few years has resulted in any concrete action.

By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

When in trouble or in doubt, order a commission of inquiry. It's become the most convenient band aid for political expediency when governments are faced with official lapses and security failures. In most cases, starkly illustrated by the long-running Liberhan Commission, it either succeeds in burying the truth or delaying the verdicts and the disclosures of actual facts to the point where it becomes meaningless. It is also a political weapon used by the Opposition to embarrass the party in power and simultaneously appeal to specific votebanks. As is clearly the case with the recent demand by politicians like Amar Singh, Mamata Banerjee and even Union Minister

Kapil Sibal for a judicial inquiry into the Batla House encounter in which two alleged terrorists were shot dead in a Muslim-dominated colony in the capital, despite the fact that a highly decorated police inspector also lost his life in the encounter. Sibal's motivation is electorally inspired: the area is Muslim-dominated like his constituency, Chandni Chowk, and with polls due soon, it is the best way to encash on the sentiments of voters. Singh and Banerjee are eyeing the minority community. Recently, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh turned down the request for a judicial probe into the encounter.

Even minus such motives, judicial inquiries have reached their expiry date. Lacking the power of arrest, search and seizure, a judicial inquiry only results in making statutory investigations redundant, seldom succeeding in the purpose: an independent, speedy method to get at the truth. Not a single probe in the past few years has resulted in any concrete action. An inquiry like the Liberhan Commission, probing the Babri Masjid demolition for the past 16 years, is now on its 47th extension, with each one promising to be the last one. Other inquiries involving